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**A DISTANT EMBRACE** Modi greets Trudeau at Bharat Mandapam during the G20 summit, Sept. 9

sociated with Punjab's notorious Davinder Bambiha gang operating in Canada, was shot down in Winnipeg. Sukhdool was the henchman of Arshdeep Singh Dala, a gangster and member of Nijjar's KTF, and the killing was seen as part of the intergang rivalry with Lawrence Bishnoi, the other powerful Punjab ganglord. Bishnoi is one of the key suspects in the killing of popular Punjab singer Sidhu Moosewala. It is this nexus between extortion gangs, drug warlords and extremists that is a key worry for India as many of them seek refuge in Canada when the police crack down on them. India believes Pakistan's Inter-Services Intelligence is trying to revive the Khalistan issue after failing to stir trouble in Kashmir. Intelligence officials are keen to nip such attempts in the bud. With Trudeau at the helm, Canada has so far been insensitive to India's security interests, which has become a major reason for the deteriorating relations between the two countries.

Indian foreign policy experts believe there are several major reasons why Trudeau took the explosive route of briefing the Canadian parliament on the Nijjar issue rather than relying on diplomacy to sort out issues with India. For one, *The Globe and Mail*, Canada's leading daily newspaper, was about to break the story of India's involvement in the Nijjar killing. And Trudeau was keen to pre-empt criticism in Parliament that he had dined with Modi at the G20 while India was seemingly violating Canada's sovereignty. It would also divert attention not just from the charge of being soft on China over its transgressions but equally from the economic woes, including the high cost of living, that have beset Canada. Most importantly, it would ensure that NDP would not pull out of his government given that the party has a large support base among Sikhs. It may also consolidate Trudeau's Sikh vote bank for 2025. As an Indian diplomat put it, "For Trudeau, the opportunity presented was like killing four birds with one stone."

Some experts see a US hand in this development because it was American intelligence agencies that shared information about India's involvement. The US motive, they believe, is to bring India down a couple of notches after its G20 assertiveness. Since America is likely to mediate between Canada and India to cool down temperatures, New Delhi's obligations to the US will only grow. Others dismiss the assessment, saying the US was not only blindsided but conflicted by this development. The US is forced to balance its interests between a close strategic ally (Canada) and a growing strategic partner (India). Moreover, Canada has yet to provide any evidence that implicates India, and Trudeau's political opponents will go after him if it does not come soon. On his part, Trudeau feels that India, by hinging its relations with Canada solely on the Khalistan issue, is making a mountain out of a molehill as the population of expat Sikhs is minuscule in his country.

## TIME TO GET ON THE RAMP

Most experts call for the two countries to de-escalate diplomatic tensions because of the high stakes involved in the relationship, especially the growing economic ties. Trade in goods and services between India and Canada has steadily grown to $8 billion (approx. Rs 66,500 crore) in India's favour, but is well short of the potential. Canadians have begun to invest heavily in India, especially with pension funds accounting for an estimated $55 billion (nearly Rs 4.6 lakh crore). Close to 226,000 Indian students were studying in Canada in 2022, traffic that has grown in recent years. There's also a large Indian immigrant population seeking job opportunities. With India's growing importance as bulwark against China and pivot in the Asia-Pacific, both areas that align with Canada's forward-leaning policy, it is in Ottawa's interest to nurture its relationship with New Delhi. Trudeau, having demonstrated to Sikhs that he stood up for them and "withstood India's bullying", can assuage India by cracking down on major Khalistan extremists operating in the country, without facing flak from his domestic constituents.

Rather than suspend visa issuance to all Canadians, India should focus on cancelling visas and passports of PIO card-holders conducting proven extremist activities in addition to confiscating their physical and monetary assets in India for being absconders from justice. As a former Indian High Commissioner to Canada put it, "Both sides need to get on the ramp and off the highway so that quiet negotiations are possible rather than speeding headlong into conflict." The problem is, as another Indian diplomat put it, "when you smell blood, as Trudeau has done, you don't know where to the draw the line." He believes that the relationship will go into cold storage for the next two years till Canada's 2025 general election. Others are optimistic and advocate that the two countries return to the diplomatic table, for, however intractable the situation may seem, diplomacy is the art of making an impossible rapprochement possible. ■